Design221 Case Study

2026 - Semester 2

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RESEARCH

Comparing visual identity, usability, and portfolio communication

VISUAL RESEARCH

REFERENCE A / SAM SCOTT



Fig. 01 / Sam Scott - homepage typography.



Fig. 02 / Sam Scott - project link detail.

Sam Scott's portfolio uses unusually large typography to establish an immediate personal identity. The name becomes the main visual element instead of relying on a conventional hero image. I was interested in how a limited colour palette and minimal navigation could make a website feel more confident. However, I did not want my own projects to become secondary to the typography.

REFERENCE B / JIMMY MA

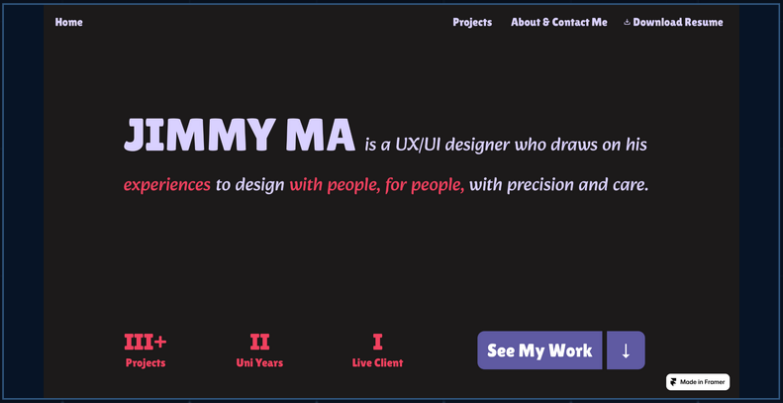


Fig. 03 / Jimmy Ma - full homepage reference.

Jimmy Ma's homepage communicates who the designer is, what he does, and how visitors can explore his work. The introduction feels personal, while the navigation stays easy to follow. I found this approach more useful for presenting a varied range of projects and skills.

COMPARISON & WHAT I TOOK FORWARD

Sam Scott showed me the value of a strong first impression; Jimmy Ma showed me the importance of clear information. For my website, I aimed to combine both: a recognisable personal identity, straightforward navigation, and enough space for visitors to examine each project. These examples informed my decisions, rather than becoming layouts to copy.

INITIAL SKETCHES

Exploring layout, navigation and the way projects are presented

INITIAL PLANNING

FIRST LAYOUT EXPLORATIONS

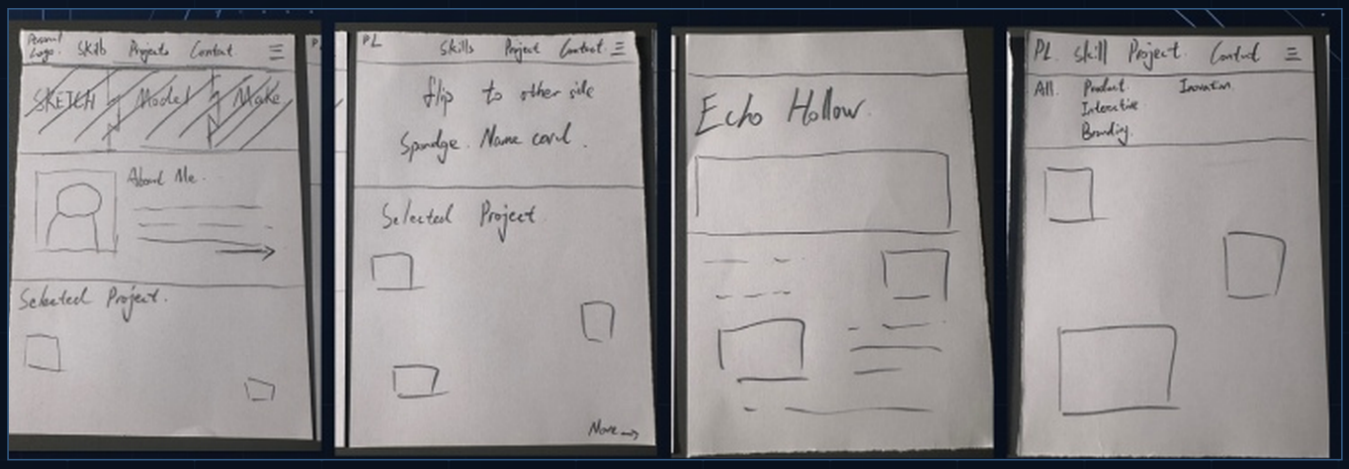


Fig. 04a / Home 04b / Navigation 04c / Project 04d / Archive

I began with quick sketches to explore the overall information structure before committing to a finished digital layout. The four options looked at a personal introduction, simplified navigation, an individual project page, and a wider project archive. I deliberately kept the drawings rough so I could change direction without spending time perfecting details that might not work.

DECISIONS FROM THE SKETCHES

01 Clear navigation

The most important sections needed to be recognisable immediately.

02 Different levels of detail

Selected projects could introduce my work, with a separate archive for everything else.

03 Process-based case studies

I wanted space for sketches, prototypes, errors, and decisions, not only final images.

These sketches gave me a starting structure, but they were not a fixed blueprint. As soon as I began testing the website in a browser, some of the original layout ideas changed to accommodate the real content.

MAKING THE IDEA TANGIBLE

Sketch / Model / Make developed as part of a wider personal identity

PHYSICAL EXPLORATION

Although the final outcome of this practice was a website, I also explored my design identity through physical objects. I wanted the phrase “Sketch · Model · Make” to represent how I normally work: moving from rough ideas, to three-dimensional development, and finally to something I can test or use. These physical studies were related identity experiments, not screenshots from the website.

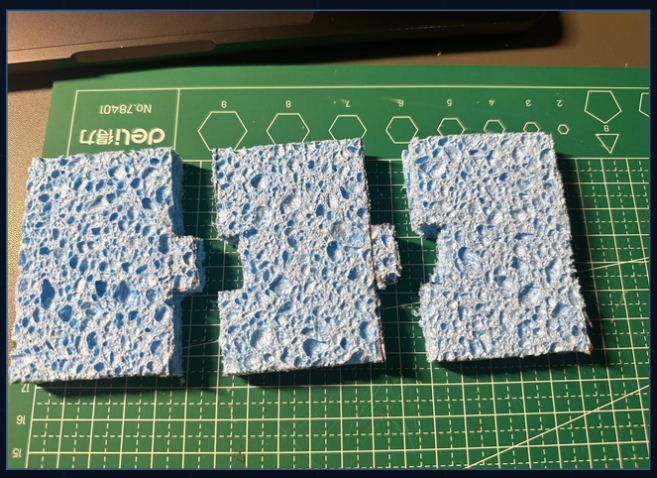


Fig. 05 / Hand-cut foam connection experiments.

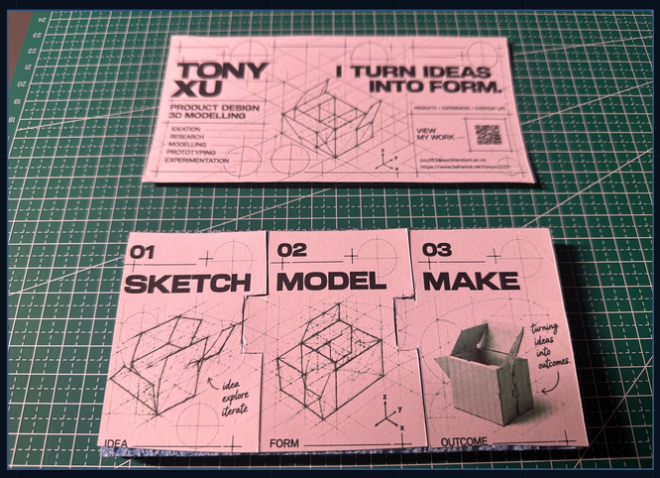


Fig. 06 / Printed Sketch, Model, Make cards.

The foam pieces allowed me to test how separate components might interlock. Their imperfect cuts and surfaces made the limitations of a physical trial visible. I then made a set of printed cards that carried the same three-stage message. The geometric drawing style, diagrams and strong type later helped me decide how the website should communicate a similar attitude toward making.

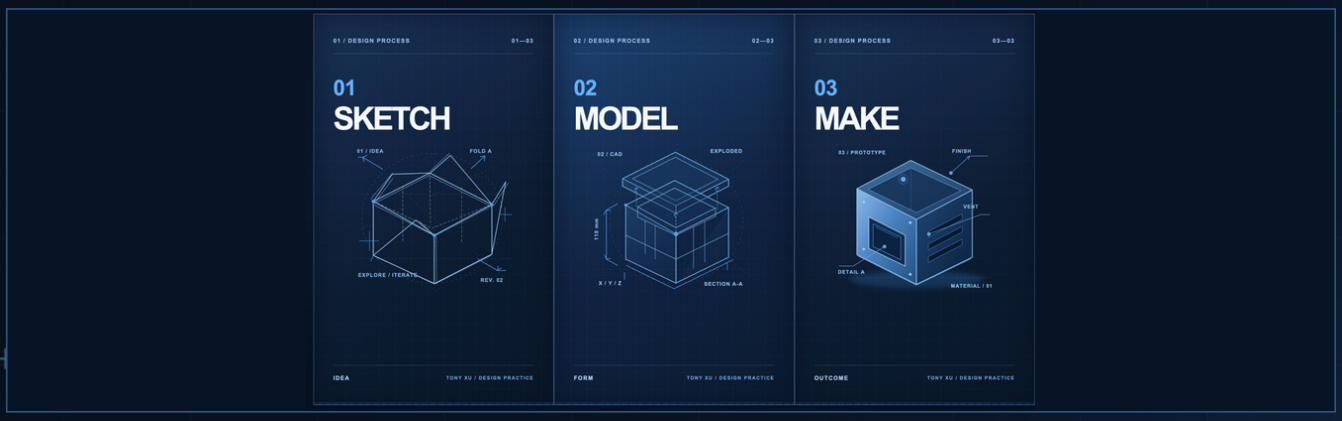


Fig. 07 / Refined graphic panels explaining the three stages of making.

The visual language was also tested digitally. AI-assisted layout exploration helped produce and compare graphic directions, but I selected the hierarchy, requested changes, and kept adjusting how the physical and digital elements related to each other.

FROM SKETCH TO BROWSER

Building functional structures before the visual system was fully resolved

WEBSITE DEVELOPMENT

I moved into website prototyping using HTML, CSS and JavaScript, with AI supporting the technical implementation. At this point I was more comfortable judging a working page than writing all of the code myself. I used each browser version to test navigation, scale and the amount of information shown at once. The early results were functional, but often too empty or disconnected from the work I actually wanted to present.



Fig. 08 / Early personal-introduction screen before the final homepage.

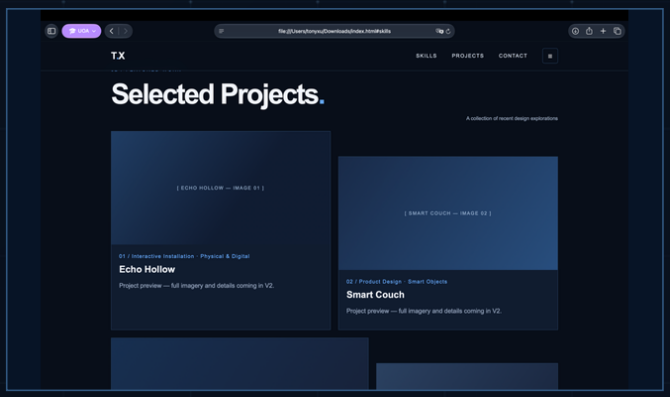


Fig. 09 / Early selected-project cards with placeholders.



Fig. 10 / Early About Me content block.

WHAT THE FIRST TESTS REVEALED

The site needed a stronger relationship between its opening and project content. Placeholder cards did not communicate the quality of my work, and the personal section still sounded too general. I also noticed that changing one part of the code could affect another page. I repeatedly asked AI to revise specific sections, tested the output, and decided which changes improved the overall experience.

OPENING ANIMATION

Developing the digital introduction through repeated interaction testing

KEY ITERATION 01

The opening animation was one of the most important and time-consuming parts of the website. I wanted visitors to understand Sketch, Model and Make through an interaction, not just read the words. The earliest version showed three simple panels, but they lacked a clear relationship to my broader identity. With AI-assisted coding, I tried changing the proportions, graphic details, transitions and the order in which the information appeared.

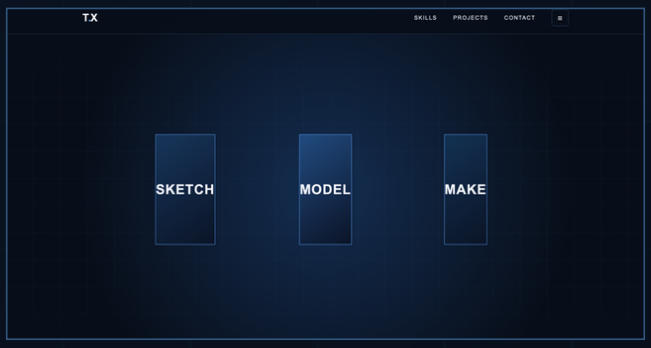


Fig. 11 / Earlier three-panel introduction.

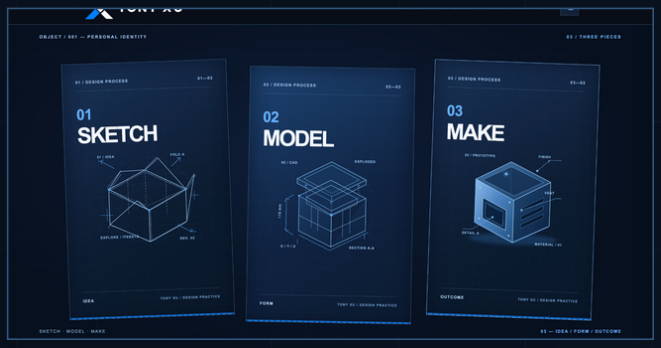


Fig. 12 / Developed cards with design diagrams.

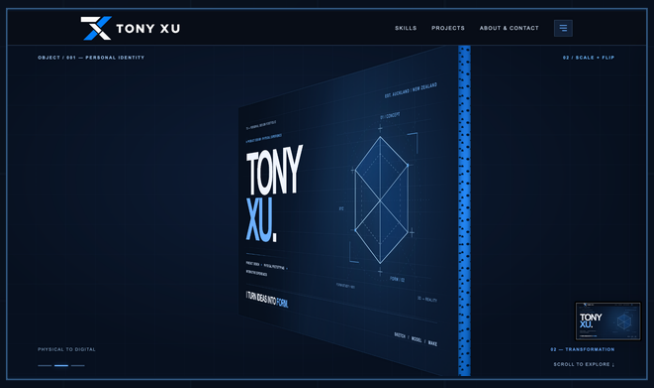


Fig. 13 / Scale-and-flip transition.

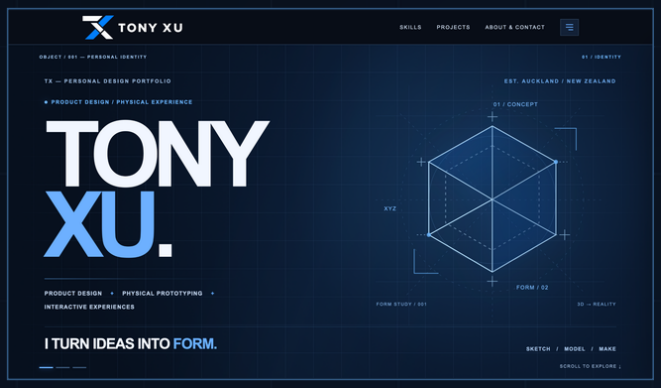


Fig. 14 / Landing page after the transition.

WHY I CHANGED IT

The later sequence became more connected: the cards show the design stages, the flip gives the interaction a sense of movement, and the final screen introduces my name and main design direction. I repeatedly checked whether the animation felt smooth and whether text remained readable. AI helped implement the effects, but I decided the timing, visuals and corrections through ongoing testing.

LOGO DEVELOPMENT

Refining my visual identity through several practical tests

KEY ITERATION 02

My early logo was a compact TX mark. It worked as a placeholder but did not communicate my design direction clearly enough, especially when used in the website header. I explored a more geometric structure with blue and white elements, checking the balance between simplicity, recognisability and how well it fitted the blueprint visual language.



Fig. 15 / Original TX mark.



Fig. 16 / Interim symbol and wordmark.

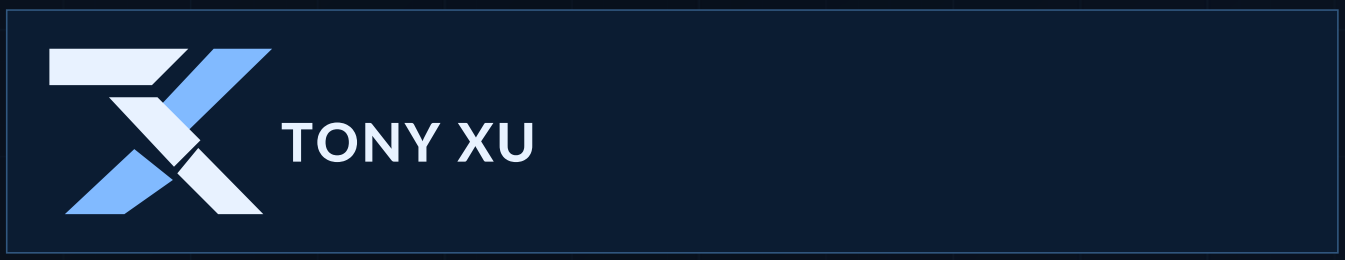


Fig. 17 / Final mark - sharp vector geometry.



Fig. 18 / Revised symbol and wordmark in the live website header.

The final decision was to keep the diagonal blue sections while removing the upright blue component that made the original symbol feel crowded. I also removed the “Design Practice” subtitle, since the portfolio represents me as an individual rather than a design studio. I compared the logo at different sizes and kept returning to the actual website header, where it needed to stay clear without taking attention away from the navigation.

PERSONAL INFORMATION

Making the bio more accurate, personal and accessible

KEY ITERATION 03

The first About Me section introduced me as a design student, but it did not properly show the direction of my practice. I wanted to make my interests in product design, physical prototyping, hands-on making and interaction more specific. At the same time I updated my CV and Behance biography, so I needed the information to stay consistent across platforms.

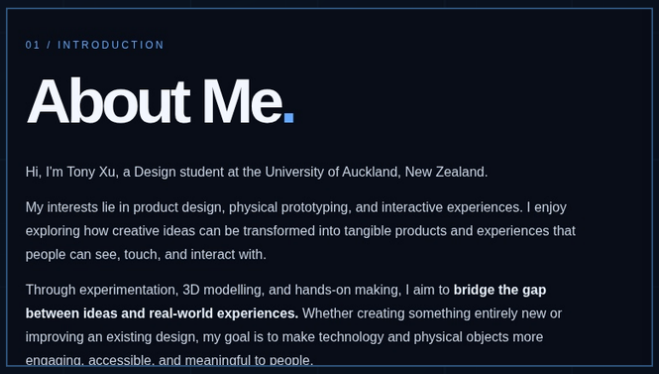


Fig. 19 / Earlier About Me introduction.

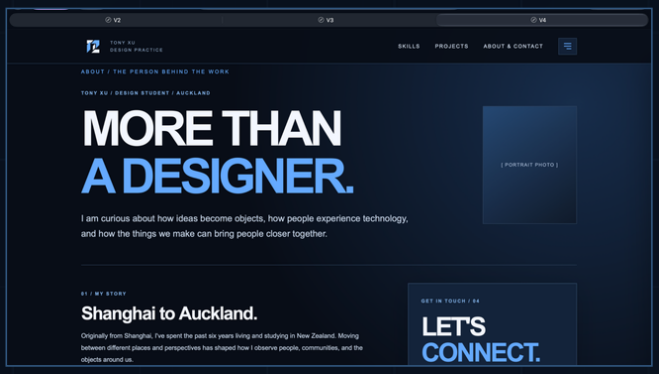


Fig. 20 / Expanded About & Contact page.

My first revisions mainly made the introduction longer, but I later realised that too much general information could also distract from the work. I rewrote the bio to explain what I actually enjoy doing: using modelling and experimentation to turn ideas into tangible outcomes. I also made the contact details and CV download link easier to find so visitors had a clear next step.

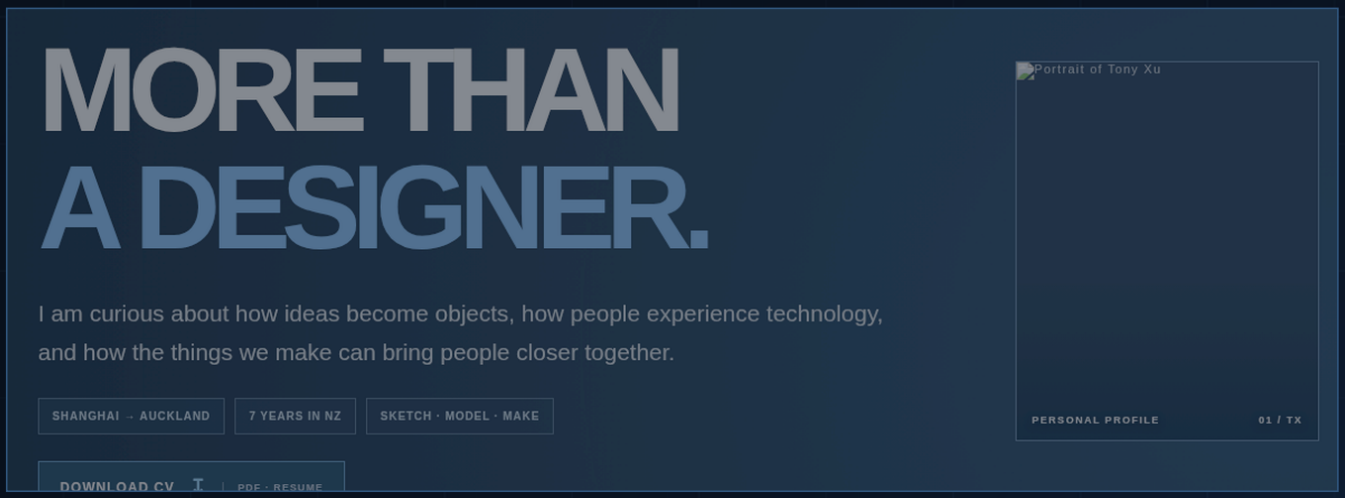


Fig. 21 / Later About & Contact screen with CV access (exposure adjusted for readability).

ORGANISING THE WORK

From inconsistent placeholders to a browsable portfolio archive

CONTENT DEVELOPMENT

A portfolio needs to do more than look finished on the homepage. I still needed a structure that made it easy to understand the different kinds of work I have done. Earlier versions relied on a few selected projects, some unfinished cards and short descriptions. I gradually separated featured projects from the full archive, adjusted the categories, and created individual pages with room for process and outcomes.

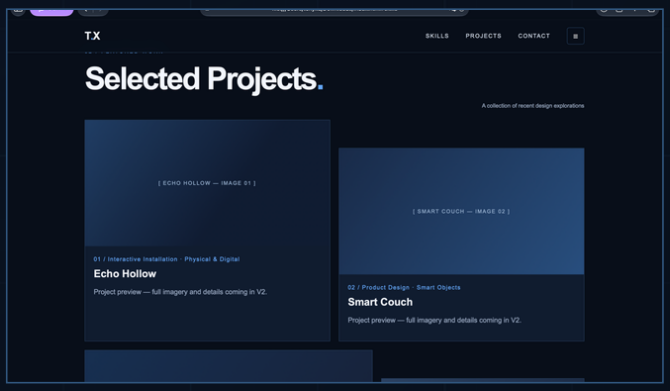


Fig. 22 / Early project cards with placeholder content.

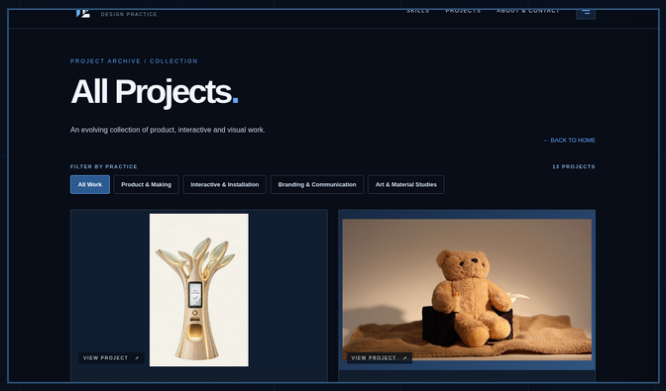


Fig. 23 / Updated archive, images and category filters.

The most difficult part was not simply building the layout. I had to check that every image belonged to the right project, that the cover represented the final outcome, and that descriptions and captions were consistent. Some AI-assisted edits introduced image mix-ups and unnecessary changes, so I repeatedly checked the site and corrected them. This became one of the clearest examples of why technical assistance still needs careful judgement.

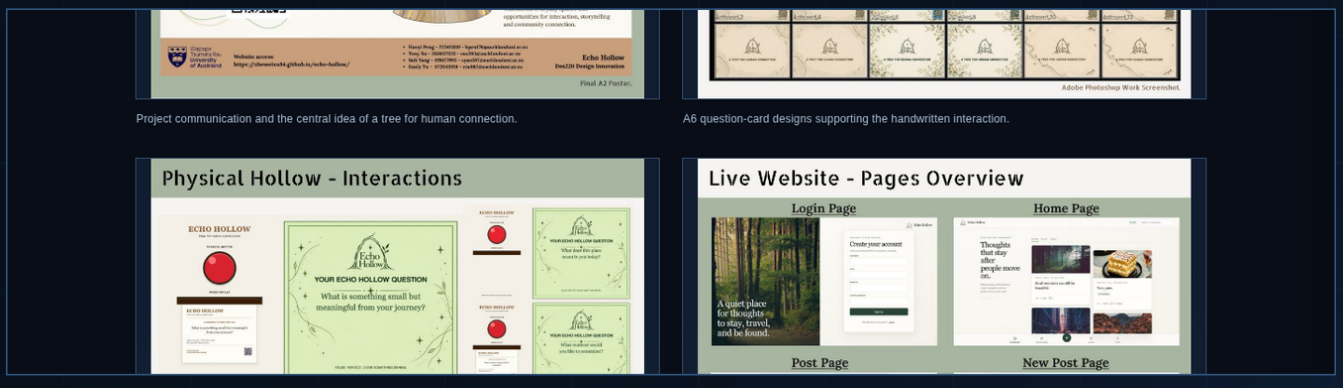


Fig. 24 / Individual case study showing process images and project outcomes.

The final archive offers a clearer route through my work, while case-study pages can explain why a design changed. For physical projects in particular, the process is part of the value - not just a supporting image.

AI AS A TOOL

Iteration required constant communication and checking

TECHNICAL WORKFLOW

I used AI throughout the website project to support code writing, interaction development and troubleshooting. I am more experienced with physical design and modelling than web programming, so AI helped me create working versions and explore options more quickly. However, this did not make the process automatic: every new function had to be checked in the browser, and later edits sometimes changed things that had previously worked.

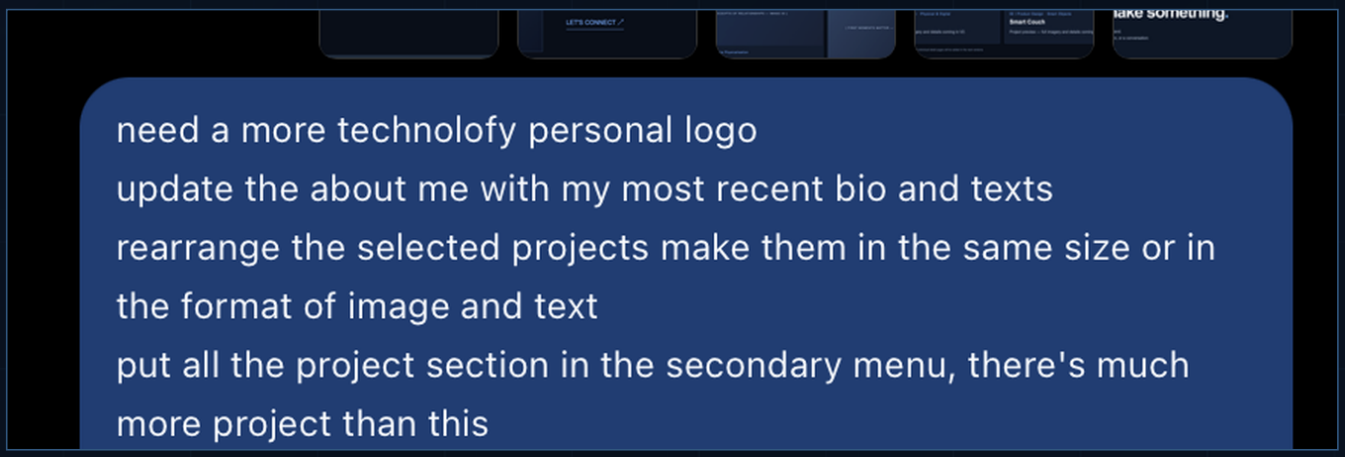


Fig. 25 / Actual conversation: I requested changes to the logo, sections and interactions.

MY WORKFLOW / REPEAT UNTIL THE DESIGN WORKS

01 **Describe the intention**
Explain what I wanted to change and why.

02 **Test a working version**
Open the HTML and check how the website behaves.

03 **Identify mistakes**
Find layout issues, incorrect images or broken functions.

04 **Revise and repeat**
Give more precise feedback and test again.

The project taught me that AI outputs need to be treated like prototypes. AI supported technical implementation, but the decisions, corrections and final checks remained my responsibility. Clearer instructions and more organised assets would have reduced the amount of repeated work.

FINAL WEBSITE

A published portfolio built through making, testing and repeated revisions

FINISHED WORK

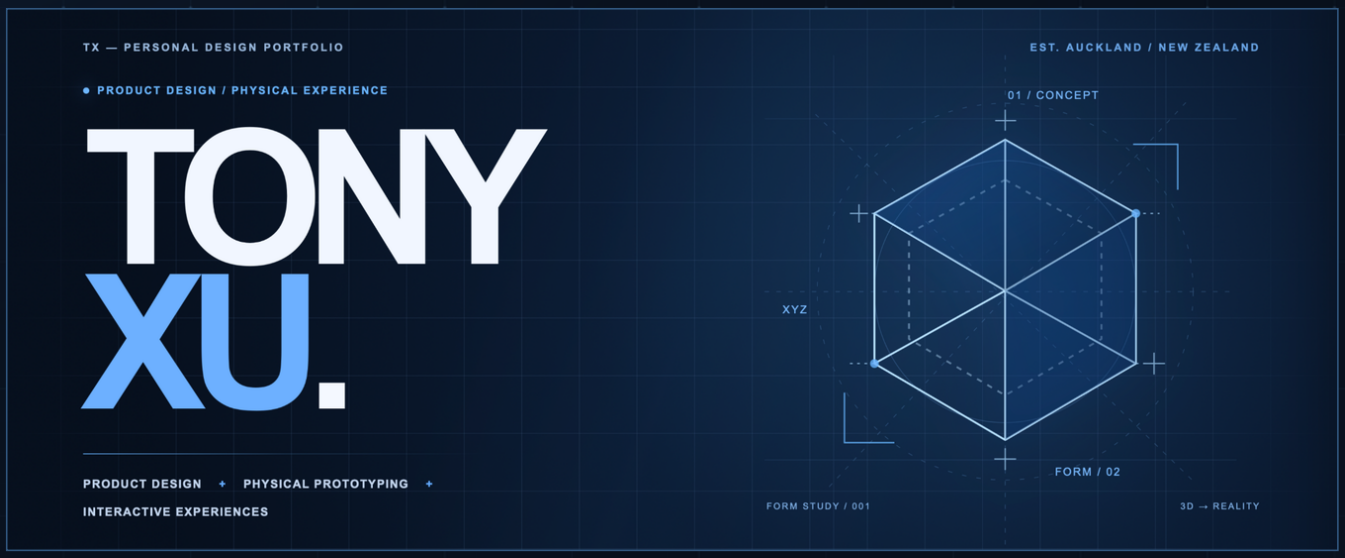


Fig. 26 / Published homepage after the interactive introduction.

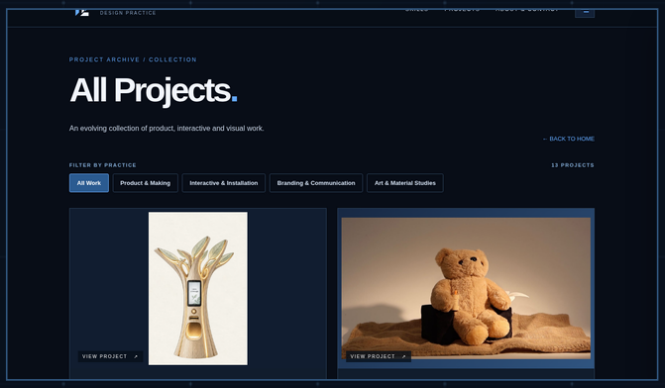


Fig. 27 / Full project archive with category navigation.



Fig. 28 / Updated About & Contact and CV download link.

Publishing the portfolio gave me a complete outcome instead of another working version saved on my laptop. The site now connects the opening interaction to a clearer visual identity, a structured project archive and more detailed case-study pages. It better communicates my interest in products, tangible experiences and interactive design.

The site will keep changing as I produce new work. Preparing the files for GitHub Pages also made me test images, videos, mobile layouts and download links. I learned that publishing and checking a design in its real environment are also important parts of the process.

LIVE PERSONAL PORTFOLIO

zheweixu84.github.io/Tony-s-personal-website/

REFLECTION

What I learned from working across physical and digital design

PERSONAL REFLECTION

01 / WHAT WAS DIFFICULT

Building this website was more complicated than I originally expected. At first, I thought the main challenge would be finding a visual style that represented me. As I continued, I realised that organising my projects, creating interactions and making every page work properly were just as important as the visual design. The site changed many times because I was learning what it needed while actually using it.

02 / MY WORKING STYLE

One of my strengths was being able to turn an idea into something testable quite quickly. I prefer making a version, looking at the result and then improving it, rather than spending too long planning every detail. This helped me try different opening animations, logo directions and project layouts. However, it also caused unnecessary work. I had not organised the project images and content carefully enough from the beginning, so I later had to fix incorrect images, rethink some categories and rewrite parts of the website.

03 / WORKING WITH AI

AI was a major part of my process, especially because web development is not my strongest area. It helped me create code, test interactive ideas and solve technical issues. At the same time, the results were not always accurate. Sometimes it misunderstood a request or changed something that was already working. I had to keep explaining, checking, correcting and trying again. This taught me that AI can make a difficult technical task more accessible, but it does not replace clear communication or independent design judgement.

04 / PHYSICAL TO DIGITAL

What I found most interesting was bringing my usual Sketch, Model and Make approach into a digital project. I normally prefer working with physical products, models and materials. Making the printed cards and translating that design language into a website showed me that the same way of thinking can work across different media. I am happy that I now have a published portfolio which feels closer to who I am as a designer.

05 / NEXT STEPS

For my next project, I want to organise the content and basic structure earlier, especially when several projects and different types of media are involved. I still want to keep the speed and experimentation of my current process, but combine them with clearer planning, more careful testing and better documentation.

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